C-A TEAM · TADC CGV PROJECT

ElevenLabs setup guide

From a new account to recording character lines with your own key

Updated 29 October 2026

Tools: `npm run voices`, `npm run sounds`

Read this first: not every account can use our voices

- Our six character voices are ElevenLabs **default voices**. ElevenLabs only gives default voices to **accounts created before March 2026**, and removes them for everyone on **31 December 2026**.
- If you already have an ElevenLabs account from before March 2026, **use that one**. A brand-new account (free or paid) won't have these voices, and free accounts can't use Voice Library voices through the API at all.
- Step 4 tells you for sure in a few seconds, without spending credits. If it says **MISSING**, stop there and tell Kamogelo. Please don't swap in other voices to make it work: the characters would change voice mid-game.
- Clips already in the repo keep working after December. The game plays the recorded MP3 files and never calls ElevenLabs.

What you need

- The C-A project on your machine with `npm install` done.
- Node.js 22 or newer (check with `node --version`).
- An email address or Google account for ElevenLabs.

1 Create your account (or log in)

1. Go to elevenlabs.io and click **Sign up**. Email or Google both work. If you already have an account, just log in.
2. Verify your email, then answer the short onboarding questions however you like.
3. Stay on the **Free** plan. It gives **10,000 credits a month** and needs no card. Turn off any VPN while signing up and recording: ElevenLabs can block free accounts it thinks look unusual.

The free plan asks you to credit ElevenLabs. The game's Credits panel already does.

2 Create the API key

1. In the left sidebar click **Developers**, then the **API Keys** tab (direct link: elevenlabs.io/app/developers/api-keys).
2. Click **Create Key** and name it something like *TADC CGV voices*.
3. Leave **Restrict Key** switched **on**, then set the permissions below. The list is long; anything not in this table stays on **No Access**.

PERMISSION	SET TO	WHAT OUR TOOLS USE IT FOR
Text to Speech	Access	Recording dialogue lines (`npm run voices`)
Sound Effects	Access	Recording ambience, the knock and the snore (`npm run sounds`)
Voices	Read	Checking your account has the cast voices
User	Read	Optional: shows your credits left before each run
Everything else	No Access	Not used. Don't give Voices *Write*, and don't switch Restrict Key off.

4. **Credit limit** is optional. Leave it unlimited, or set a cap to protect your monthly credits.
5. Click **Create** and **copy the key straight away** (it starts with `sk_`). ElevenLabs only shows it once. If you lose it, delete it from the ··· menu and create a new one.

ElevenLabs sometimes renames or regroups these settings. If a name doesn't match exactly, pick the closest one.

3 Add the key to the project

1. In VS Code, create a file named `.env` in the **C-A** folder (the same folder as `package.json`).

2. Put this one line in it, with your own key, and no quotes or spaces:

```
ELEVENLABS_API_KEY=sk_paste_your_key_here
```

3. Run `git status`. `.env` must **not** show up; it's already in `.gitignore`.

> **Keep the key secret**
> Never commit it, paste it into WhatsApp, Discord or Jira, or put it anywhere in `src/`. Don't rename it to start with `VITE_` either, because Vite would put it in the game for anyone to read. If it leaks, delete it on the API Keys page and make a new one.

4 Check your key and voices (free)

From the C-A folder run:

```
npm run voices -- --check-key
```

A good result looks like this:

```
  ok       pomni    Jessica  cgSgspJ2msm6clMCkdW9
  ok       ragatha  Sarah    EXAVITQu4vr4xnSDxMaL
  ok       caine    Liam     TX3LPaxmHKxFdv7VOQHJ
  ok       kaufmo   Callum   N2lVS1w4EtoT3dr4eOWO
  ok       ribbit   Lily     pFZP5JQG7iQjIQuC4Bku
  ok       jax      Chris    iP95p4xoKVk53GoZ742B
  credits left this month: 10000
Key works and the account has every cast voice.
```

Any **MISSING** line means your account doesn't have that voice (see *Read this first*). This check covers the key itself and the Voices and User permissions. Text to Speech and Sound Effects get checked on your first real run: if one is off, the tool stops at the first line with `missing_permissions` and nothing is charged.

5 The character voices

You don't choose voices on the website. The tool always uses these exact voices, by voice ID, with these settings. Use this table if you want to try a line on the website's Text to Speech page first.

CHARACTER	ELEVENLABS VOICE	VOICE ID	SPEED	STABILITY	HOW THEY SHOULD SOUND
Pomni	**Jessica**	`cgSgspJ2msm6clMCkdW9`	1.00	0.45	Anxious, deadpan
Ragatha	**Sarah**	`EXAVITQu4vr4xnSDxMaL`	1.00	0.50	Warm, strained
Caine	**Liam**	`TX3LPaxmHKxFdv7VOQHJ`	1.10	0.30	Manic ringmaster
Kaufmo	**Callum**	`N2lVS1w4EtoT3dr4eOWO`	1.08	0.30	Jittery clown
Ribbit	**Lily**	`pFZP5JQG7iQjIQuC4Bku`	0.92	0.55	Withdrawn
Jax	**Chris**	`iP95p4xoKVk53GoZ742B`	1.00	0.35	Sarcastic, cutting

> **Shared settings**
> - Model **Eleven Flash v2.5**, half the credits of the other models.
> - Similarity 0.75 and seed 3006, so a re-record comes out near-identical.
> - A line's mood nudges speed and stability; muttered or whispered lines play quieter.

> **Please don't**
> - Add Voice Library look-alikes: *Callum - Husky Trickster* isn't Kaufmo's Callum.
> - Edit `CAST` in `tools/generateVoices.mjs`: that re-records all of the character's lines.
> - Share keys. Everyone uses their own.

6 Record lines

1. `npm run voices -- --check` lists the lines that still need recording. It runs offline and costs nothing.
2. `npm run voices` records only new or changed lines. It prints the estimated credits first and stops if you don't have enough.
3. Play the scene in game to listen, then commit the new MP3s in `public/audio/voice/` together with `manifest.json`.
4. Before you record, say which lines you're doing (a comment on the Jira card works), so two people don't pay for the same lines.

Sound effects work the same way: `npm run sounds -- --check`, then `npm run sounds`.

WHAT	COST
Dialogue	0.5 credits per character (a 100-character line is about 50)
The whole script	About 9,900 characters, roughly 5,000 credits
Sound effects	40 credits per second (a 12 s loop is 480)

AVOID	BECAUSE
`--force`	Re-records every line, about 5,000 credits
`--provider=edge`	Replaces every voice with Microsoft Edge voices
`--over-budget`	Starts a run you can't afford; it stops partway when credits run out

7 If something goes wrong

YOU SEE	WHAT TO DO
`No ElevenLabs API key`	`.env` is missing, in the wrong folder, or the name is misspelled (check it isn't `.env.txt`).
`401` … `invalid_api_key`	The key is mistyped or was deleted. Copy it again, or make a new one.
`401` … `missing_permissions`	Switch on the permission it names: API Keys, ··· next to the key, **Edit**.
`MISSING` or `This account doesn't have` …	The account was created after March 2026. See *Read this first* and tell Kamogelo.
`402` … `library voices via the API`	A voice was changed to a Voice Library one. Undo that change to the cast.
`Not enough credits for ~N`	Wait for your monthly reset, or record fewer lines this time.
`this key can't read the credit balance`	User: Read is off. That's fine; check your credits on the website.
`Unusual activity detected`	ElevenLabs flagged the free account, often because of a VPN. Turn it off, or contact ElevenLabs support.
`429` or a busy error	The tool retries by itself. Free accounts only allow two requests at a time.

Sources: ElevenLabs Help Center, What are Default voices? (account cut-off, 31 December 2026 expiry, voice IDs); Voices (Voice Library voices and the free API); API authentication and How do I authorize myself using an API key? (key restrictions, credit limits). Checked 29 October 2026.